rule. Akbar seemed to fear no enemy as much as he dreaded a challenge from a prince of the royal blood. After all, Humayun's many humiliations were almost entirely due to challenges from his own brothers, especially Kamran, which Akbar would have known about. Now those challenges appeared before Akbar, too, in the shape of Kamran's sons, and Akbar's half-brother, Mirza Hakim. It did not matter that the princes themselves were inconsequential, or that Mirza Hakim was only twelve years old at the time. What mattered was the legitimacy they could claim in the name of Timur and Babur, and the dangerous factions they could gather around themselves from among those dissatisfied by Akbar's measures to bring his nobility under control. In time, as we will see, Akbar would disband the Timurid co-sovereign system altogether but at the moment, it was the Uzbeks, proud, independent, and fierce, who were rebelling in the name of Mirza Hakim.

The Uzbek clansmen, who had understood the shape of the Padshah's ambition after his action against Abdullah Khan, now decided to summon all their liegemen and supporters against what they believed was an attack against the very fabric of their clan. Ali Quli Khan began gathering an army of mercenaries that included Uzbeks, Turkmen, Afghans, and Hindustanis, an explosive assembly of some 30,000 veteran horsemen. Akbar now moved to try to isolate the Uzbeks from some of their other clansmen. He sent an emissary to Fath Khan Uzbek at Rohtas, who promised to help Akbar if he came to Jaunpur. Another emissary, to Sikandar Khan Uzbek, jagirdar of Awadh, was less successful—Sikandar defected to Ali Quli Khan. With the Uzbeks now in open revolt, Akbar led his troops from Narwar towards Jaunpur, marching at night to avoid the catastrophic heat of June, and chased the rebels into the territory of the Afghans in Bihar.

With the Uzbeks successfully out of Akbar's territory, a force was required to guard the ferry across the Ganga so that the rebels could not cross back into Mughal lands. Munim Khan, more sympathetic to the Uzbeks because of their old kinship from the time of Humayun, wanted control over the ferry. Asaf Khan, Persian immigrant and much less indulgent of the Uzbeks, was another contender to guard the crossing but the eternally vacillating Asaf Khan chose this moment to finally desert. The conversation between Munim Khan and Akbar that followed this desertion, reported by Bayazid Beg, is telling in its recording of old racial tensions